

This step-by-step guide will help you prepare your cat for import into mainland Australia from Cocos (Keeling) Islands.

While Cocos (Keeling) Islands are an Australian territory, there are plants, animals and pests that are unique to each region. This means you still need to meet certain import conditions for your cat.

This guide is for cat imports only. If you are seeking to bring your dog from Cocos (Keeling) Islands to Australia, please contact us at imports@aff.gov.au.

You can print this guide and use it as a checklist.

Need to know

This is a complex process. Before you start the import process, we recommend you read this guide in full.

- Allow 1–2 month to organise health checks, treatments and paperwork. Cats that have lived outside Australia or New Zealand may take at least 6 months to prepare for import.
- All procedures must be completed by a federal government employee.
- Fees apply for our services, such as permit assessment and inspection.
- Travel can cause stress to animals. If your cat is sick or elderly, consider if this is the right decision for them.

1

We encourage you to use an experienced pet transport agent or shipper.

Importing a cat to Australia can be a complex process.

If the cat has only lived in Australia or Cocos (Keeling) Islands, the typical timeframe is about 1 month.

It will take longer for a cat that has lived outside Australia or Cocos (Keeling) Islands. This may be at least 6-7 months, depending on travel history.

You will need to make sure your cat meets a range of import conditions. This includes veterinary checks and treatments with a federal government employee on Cocos (Keeling) Islands.

Seek help from a pet transport agent with experience in importing cats to Australia. They will help guide you through the import process.

To find a pet transport agent or shipper you can:

- search online (use terms like ‘pet transport agent Australia’)
- check the [International Pet and Animal Transportation Association \(IPATA\)](#).

We cannot recommend one agent over another. We have no influence over any fees or charges an agent may require for their services.

2

You must meet all import conditions before you can bring your cat to Australia.

Cats coming to Australia from Cocos (Keeling) Islands on a [vessel](#) via sea (either commercial or non-commercial) must also meet the import conditions in this guide.

Check if this is the right guide for you

This step-by-step guide is for cats exported from Cocos (Keeling) Islands to mainland Australia.

Cocos (Keeling) Islands are considered a [Group 1 country](#). This means it's an [approved country](#) of origin for cat imports to Australia.

Other Group 1 countries have separate step-by-step guides. These are [New Zealand](#) and [Norfolk Island](#).

Cocos (Keeling) Islands

New Zealand

Norfolk Island

[Find the right step-by-step guide](#) for your animal and country of export.

Confirm your cat is eligible for import to Australia

To be eligible for import into Australia, your cat must have either:

- only lived in Cocos (Keeling) Islands since birth, or
- only lived in Cocos (Keeling) Islands since being imported from Australia, or
- only lived in Cocos (Keeling) Islands for at least 180 days immediately before the date of export to Australia (if the cat has ever lived in a country other than Australia).

Your cat can be living with you or someone else while being prepared for export.

When you plan to export your cat, it must NOT be:

- under quarantine restrictions
- more than 40 days pregnant
- nursing kittens.

Non-domestic cat hybrids are not allowed into Australia.

This ban relates to environmental protection laws, not biosecurity laws. You will need to talk to the relevant government agency for details.

Hybrid cats NOT allowed into Australia include (but are not limited to) the following breeds and any crossbred offspring derived from them:

- Savannah cats: domestic cat (*Felis catus*) crossed with serval cat (*Felis serval*)

- Safari cats: domestic cat crossed with Geoffroy cat (*Oncifelis Geoffroyi*)
- Chausie cats: domestic cat crossed with Jungle cat (*Felis chaus*)
- Bengal cats: domestic cat crossed with Asian leopard cat (*Prionailurus bengalensis*).

Contact the Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water (DCCEEW) at exotic.species@dcceew.gov.au. They can provide more advice on hybrid animals.

Importing a hybrid breed

If an imported cat is identified as possibly being a hybrid after arrival in Australia, DCCEEW may investigate further.

Bengal cat policy change

As of 1 March 2026, Bengal cats are no longer permitted to enter Australia.

For further information on this policy change, please refer to the DCCEEW [news release](#)

If your cat is sick or old

We do not recommend importing sick or very old animals. Travel can cause them to de-stabilise and rapidly deteriorate. Even cats with well-managed chronic diseases can arrive in distress and poor health.

If your cat relies on regularly administered medication, please consider that they may be unable to get medication during transport. As a pet owner, you must consider if it's in your pet's best interests to travel the distance.

Seek advice from the Shire of Cocos (Keeling) Islands

The [Shire of Cocos Keeling Islands](#) is responsible for animal health and exports.

Only federal government employees can prepare your cat for export.

You will need to follow the Shire of Cocos (Keeling) Islands advice to prepare your cat for export.

All pre-export veterinary procedures must be completed:

- by a federal government employee
- while your cat lives on Cocos (Keeling) Islands
- before departing for Australia.

This process ensures your cat doesn't bring diseases to Australia.

The [Shire of Cocos \(Keeling\) Islands](#) will tell you:

- any local procedures or requirements you must meet before you export your cat
- how to find a federal government employee to prepare your cat for export to Australia.

Don't risk arriving in Australia with the wrong checks, treatments or certificates.

Talk to the Shire of Cocos (Keeling) Islands. They will tell you who can prepare your cat for export.

Export conditions can vary between countries. The Shire of Cocos (Keeling) Islands can advise you on extra steps you need to take that aren't in this guide.

Read through this guide

We recommend you read this whole guide before you start the import process.

Share this guide and your import permit with the federal government employee preparing your cat and pet transport company. They will help you meet all conditions.

The import process takes time.

Make sure you're aware of how far ahead of export date you need to start each step. This will be covered in more detail in your import permit.

3

Microchips are the only approved identification method. The Shire of Cocos (Keeling) Islands will use the microchip to verify your cat's identity.

A federal government employee must scan the microchip at each visit.

They will check that the microchip number is recorded on all documentation.

Your cat must be implanted with a microchip that is ISO compliant. Generally, microchips with 10 or 15 digits are ISO compliant.

Microchip numbers starting with 999 are not accepted because they are not unique.

It is essential your cat has a working compliant microchip before you start the import process.

The federal government employee must scan your cat's microchip at each veterinary visit. They must accurately record the microchip number on all documents. This is how we match your cat to its preparations and documents.

If a microchip cannot be read or is incorrect in your documents, your cat cannot be imported to Australia.

If your cat has 2 compliant microchips

Both microchips must be scanned and recorded at each veterinary visit. They must match all import documents.

If your cat has an ISO compliant microchip and a non- ISO compliant microchip, we will only use the compliant microchip.

If your cat's microchip stops working

The federal government employee should try multiple microchip scanners to read the microchip. An X-ray can be used to locate the microchip if it has moved from the implant site.

4

Allow plenty of time to get your permit before your proposed export date.

Apply for a permit as soon as you intend to travel.

Permits can take time to be issued. Most permits are issued in 20 business days. It can take up to 123 business days in some cases.

Apply for an import permit

Apply for your import permit through our Biosecurity Import Conditions system (BICON).

Be aware that applying for an import permit does not guarantee you will be issued with one.

Pay in full when you submit your application in BICON.

Extra charges may apply if information is missing, incorrect, or if an application is put on hold.

Your import permit is NOT issued.

We may require more details from you before we can issue a permit. We'll advise you of further action you can take to meet import conditions. In rare cases, we may refuse to issue an import permit.

Your import permit is issued.

Continue through the steps in this guide.

Meet all import permit conditions

If your permit is issued, you must make sure you meet all your import conditions.

The conditions will be specified on your permit. This includes specific pre-export veterinary procedures required for your cat. These conditions are mandatory.

Make sure you read all import permit conditions and understand what you need to do.

If you fail to comply with your permit conditions, your cat may be:

- moved to and held in post entry quarantine

- subject to additional testing
- exported
- euthanised.

You will also be liable for any costs involved.

The permit must be valid on the date your cat arrives in Australia.

5

Plan enough time to complete all required vet checks and treatments.

You can send your cat by sea or air. You can use any operator or airline, at their discretion.

You can make the travel arrangements yourself or use an animal transport company.

Find a list of animal transport companies on the [International Pet and Animal Transportation Association \(IPATA\) website](#).

Travel by air

Your cat must travel:

- as manifested cargo (not in the cabin)
- in an International Air Transport Association (IATA) approved crate.

imports@aff.gov.au.

Domestic transfers

We will inspect your cat and their import documents at the first point of entry in Australia.

If your cat is connecting with a domestic flight, you'll need to arrange for it to be moved from the international to the domestic terminal of the airport.

Animal transport agents or pet shippers can help you with this. Find a [list of pet shippers](#) on the IPATA website.

Do not book a connecting flight within 1 hour of your animal arriving in Australia.

Allow at least 1 hour for your cat to be released by airline cargo and cleared by us.

Travel by sea

Your cat may travel directly to Australia from Cocos (Keeling) Islands on a private vessel.

Cats travelling on a vessel from Cocos (Keeling) Islands directly to Australia do not need to travel as manifested cargo. They must be secure on the vessel and arrive at a [first point of entry](#) for live cats. They must meet all health certificate requirements and import permit conditions.

No cats except those for import to Australia may be carried on the voyage without our prior approval.

Find out [more about animals on vessels](#).

6

These must be completed by a federal government employee in Cocos (Keeling) Islands

Check all timings of treatments as soon as possible.

Plan early. You need to make sure you complete all treatments in the correct timeframes before export.

All preparations are calculated from the date of export, local time in the country of export. For calculating timeframes, the date of the treatment or preparation counts as 'day 0'.

Book a pre-export appointment with a federal government employee

All preparations must be done:

- by a federal government employee
- in Cocos (Keeling) Islands.

To find a federal government employee contact the [Shire of Cocos \(Keeling\) Islands](#).

imports@aff.gov.au.

We recommend you share this step-by-step guide with the federal government employee.

They can help you make sure you meet all import conditions. This information is also useful to share with pet transport companies.

Check recommended vaccinations

This is an optional step.

We recommend that your cat is vaccinated against diseases that are present in Australia.

Some Australian states and territories have their own vaccination requirements. It's your responsibility to check and comply with these.

We recommend that your cat is vaccinated against:

- feline enteritis (also known as feline panleucopenia or feline distemper)
- rhinotracheitis

- calicivirus.

These diseases exist in Australia.

Treat for external parasites

Your cat must be treated with a topical product that kills ticks and fleas on contact within 5 days before the date of export to Australia.

The chosen product must remain effective against new flea and tick infestations until the date of export to Australia. Oral treatments for external parasites do not generally meet Australian import conditions.

The federal government officer may need to repeat treatment to maintain protection until export. They must follow the manufacturer's directions. If the reapplication periods for fleas and ticks differ, you must follow the shortest reapplication period.

At each visit after the treatment has started, the federal government officer must examine your cat for external parasites. If fleas or ticks are found they must be removed, and the treatment restarted.

See [acceptable external parasite treatments](#).

Do this within 5 days before the date of export to Australia. Repeat according to manufacturer's directions.

To calculate 5 days before the date of export, count the first day the treatment as day 0. For example, if treatment is given 1 January, then the latest date of export is 6 January.

Treat for internal parasites

A federal government employee must treat your cat with a compliant internal parasite treatment effective against [nematodes and cestodes](#) (internal parasites). This must be done within 5 days before the date of export to Australia.

See [acceptable internal parasite treatments](#).

Do this within 5 days before the date of export to Australia.

To calculate 5 days before the date of export, count the first day of treatment as day 0. For example, if treatment is given on 1 January, then the latest date of export is 6 January.

Ask a federal government employee about products that cover both nematodes and cestodes

Combined products that cover both nematodes and cestodes are available in many countries.

Time saver

It's acceptable to do the final health check and internal and external parasite treatments at the same vet visit.

These are the final preparation activities before you export your cat.

Cats coming to mainland Australia from Cocos (Keeling) Islands must have a valid import permit and health certificate.

The veterinary health certificate is Appendix 1 of your import permit. Take your valid import permit to this appointment.

Get a federal government employee to complete your veterinary health certificate

Make sure the right person fills in each part of the veterinary health certificate.

Parts 1 and 2 are completed by the animal's owner or representative.

Parts 3 and 4 are completed by a federal government employee.

Parts 1 and 2

You must declare the details of your cat. These include:

- name, breed, sex, age and microchip number
- name and address of exporter on Cocos (Keeling) Islands
- name and address of consignee in mainland Australia
- scheduled date of export and flight number
- your cat has resided on Cocos (Keeling) Islands for 180 days or since birth, or import from Australia
- that they are not under quarantine restrictions

Parts 3 and 4

A federal government employee must certify that your cat has been:

- examined within 5 days before the date of export
- is free of ticks, infections and contagious disease and is fit to travel
- has been treated for internal and external parasites within 5 days before the date of export.

They must certify that in the 12 months before the date of export, Cocos (Keeling) Islands has had no cases of rabies.

They must also certify that no animals have been imported into Cocos (Keeling) Islands except from Australia and New Zealand within 5 years before the date of export.

Book a pre-export clinical examination

Your cat must be examined for external parasites and clinical signs of infectious or contagious disease. A federal government employee must do this within 5 days of the date of export.

You must bring a copy of the veterinary health certificate to this visit. The veterinary health certificate is Appendix 1 of your import permit. The federal government employee will complete their section.

The federal government employee must declare that the animal is:

- free from external parasites and clinical signs of infectious or contagious disease
- has been treated for internal and external parasites
- fit for travel.

It's acceptable to do the internal and external parasite treatments at the same time as the final vet check.

Check office hours and timeframes

Government offices may be closed over local public holidays and weekends. You will need to make sure that you have enough time to get the veterinary health certificate endorsed before export.

Gather your import documents

Send all import documents with your cat.

Your valid import permit and veterinary health certificate must travel to Australia with your cat.

Keep a copy of each document for your records.

Your cat must arrive in Australia with these documents:

- a valid import permit
- a veterinary health certificate.

The veterinary health certificate must be an original document. Copies will not be accepted.

Notify us

Email the regional office in the state or territory your cat will first arrive in Australia.

Your email must include:

- the date and estimated time of arrival
- the flight number (unless travelling via vessel)
- the air waybill number (unless travelling via vessel)
- a short description of your cat
- a contact phone number in Australia or New Zealand

If your cat is coming to Australia from Cocos (Keeling) Island on a vessel, the vessel master must notify us at least 3 days before arrival at the first port of entry in Australia.

Office contacts in Australia

- New South Wales – ceranimalimports@aff.gov.au
- Victoria – seanimal@aff.gov.au AND VIC.Controller@aff.gov.au
- Queensland – qldliveanimalimports@aff.gov.au
- South Australia – cargosa@aff.gov.au
- Western Australia – animalswa@aff.gov.au
- Tasmania – tas.controller@aff.gov.au
- Northern Territory – ntliveanimalimports@aff.gov.au
- Australian Capital Territory – actregoffice@aff.gov.au

General inquiry: 1800 900 090 or + 61 3 8318 6700 (from outside Australia)

8

What to do when you're ready to send your cat, and what will happen when they arrive.

Pay fees and charges

You will be charged for the time taken to assess the documents that arrive with your cat.

Details of our fees can be found in our [charging guidelines](#). Contact the relevant state or territory office to determine the fees for clearing your cat.

Fees are usually collected by the airline carrying your animal. The payment should appear on the air waybill (issued by the airline). We will invoice the airline to recover the fees.

Make sure your air waybill includes details of fees you have paid.

If the air waybill does not include these fees, you will need to pay us before your animal is released.

Prepare your cat for air travel

On the day of air travel:

- place your cat in an [International Air Transport Association \(IATA\)](#) approved crate (see Step 5)
- do not place any items, including toys, medication or items of value, in the crate (these will be destroyed as biosecurity waste upon arrival)

In most cases, you will check your cat in at the freight terminal, not the passenger terminal.

If your cat is travelling with you on a private vessel, refer to our [animals on vessels](#) page for more information.

When your cat arrives in Australia

A biosecurity officer will check the cat. They must verify that all details match the import documents.

Your animal will be released from biosecurity control if everything is acceptable. If not, more documents may be requested.

If your cat is transferring to a domestic flight, this can happen after they are cleared by us.

Register your cat in Australia

You are responsible for meeting any local requirements in Australia.

Contact your local Australian council or government. They can tell you what you must do. This might include registering your cat and their microchip and paying yearly fees.

Your local veterinary hospital or animal shelter may also be able to advise you.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs/how-to-import/step-by-step-guides/category1-cocos>